



MMA / Boxing Pregame Neural Warm-Up

6–8 minutes

"Stretching gets you loose. Neural warm-ups get you sharp." — Dr. Shah

This is **SEE** → **DECIDE** → **MOVE**, at fight speed.

1

Monocular Eye Control

30–45 sec

Why: Reduces eye dominance issues → cleaner reads on the lead hand, sharper depth in the pocket

How

- Cover one eye
- With the open eye, trace this pattern in space or on the wall:
 - Up left → up right
 - Middle left → middle right
 - Down left → down right
- Hit each corner once
- Switch eyes

Coaching cue

"Smooth eyes. No rushing. No head movement."

If one eye feels jumpy, you just found a performance leak before the first bell.

2

Saccades: Horizontal + Vertical

45–60 sec

Why: Faster reads on combos, slips, and angle changes — see the second strike before it lands

How

- Two fingers at eye level
- Horizontal: left ↔ right (20–30 reps)
- Vertical: up ↑ down (20–30 reps)
- Head still, jaw relaxed

Coaching cue

"Eyes snap. Face stays quiet."

■ **If the head moves → you're telegraphing before you've even thrown.**

3

Depth Perception Switch (Thumb Near–Far Cycling)

45–60 sec

Why: Combat is constant **near-far depth switching** (your hands → opponent's hips → eyes → hands)

How

- Thumb at arm's length
- **Look past your thumb** → let it double
- **Look in front of your thumb** → let the background double
- Move back and forth smoothly
- **10 controlled cycles**

Coaching cue

"Clear → double → clear. Own the range."

This is the difference between catching the jab early and eating it.

4

VOR + Head-Slip Sequence

60 sec

Why: Eye stability while slipping, ducking, and rolling — keep the target locked while the body moves

How

- Thumb at arm's length
- Lock eyes on thumb
- Slip head left ↔ right
- **Add a duck** at the end of each cycle, then return upright
- 5–6 reps each side

Coaching cue

"Eyes stay locked. Body moves underneath."

5

Soft Focus → Hard Focus on Thumb

60 sec

Why: Trains the switch between broad threat awareness and pinpoint targeting — defense to offense in one beat

How

- Thumb at arm's length, eye level
- **Soft focus:** let the thumb stay clear but take in the whole room around it (~5 sec)
- **Hard focus:** snap onto a single detail on the thumb — a line, a nail, a print (~3 sec)
- Cycle **8–10 times**, smooth transitions in both directions

Coaching cue

"See wide. Then see sharp."

Soft focus reads movement. Hard focus picks the shot.

6

Locker-Room Peripheral Reaction Drill

60–90 sec

Why: Reaction time off peripheral input — most clean strikes are seen out of the corner of the eye *first*. No space needed; works in any locker room.

How — with a partner

- Stand facing each other, eyes fixed on partner's nose — do not move your eyes
- Partner holds up fingers in your peripheral field (left, right, high, low)
- Call the number out loud the instant you detect it
- Progress to **asymmetric motion** — one hand fast, one hand slow
- 10 random calls per side

How — solo

- Pick a fixed point straight ahead (a spot on the wall, a hook, a tile seam)
- Without moving your eyes, count what you can detect in your periphery — outlets, ceiling tiles, lockers, switches
- 30 seconds left side, 30 seconds right side

Coaching cue

"Don't look at it. Detect it."

The first inch of every defensive read comes from your periphery — train it before you need it.